MILK & MILK PRODUCTS

Policies, Customer Guidelines, Food Safety Notes & Frequently Asked Questions

Document type	Practical policy and FAQ template for a dairy business
Prepared for	Retail shop, dairy brand, milk delivery service or small dairy operation
Use	Adapt before publishing; fill in your business details and confirm local legal requirements
Version	General template — October 2026

Important: This document is an operational template, not legal advice or a substitute for a food-safety plan. Product shelf life, storage temperature, allergen statements, labeling, licences, tax, consumer-protection and food-safety obligations must be confirmed for your location and product type. Never use a generic shelf-life estimate in place of the validated label or manufacturer guidance.

Business name: _____

Address / contact: _____

Effective date: _____ Policy owner: _____

1. Purpose, Scope & Core Principles

This policy pack sets out clear expectations for selling, handling, delivering and supporting customers who buy milk and milk products. It is intended to help staff work consistently and help customers understand how to order, store and use products safely.

• **Safety first:** protect products from contamination, temperature abuse and damage throughout receipt, storage, preparation and delivery.

• **Honest information:** describe products accurately, including type, quantity, ingredients, allergens, price, pack size and applicable dates.

• **Traceability:** keep supplier, batch/lot, receipt, dispatch and complaint records sufficient to investigate concerns and carry out a recall if needed.

• **Respectful service:** treat customers fairly, respond promptly and never discourage a customer from reporting a possible safety issue.

• **Compliance:** follow applicable food-safety, labelling, weights-and-measures, consumer-protection, privacy and local business rules.

2. Product Categories & Information

Adapt this list to the products actually sold. Ingredients, processing, storage requirements and shelf life vary by product and supplier.

Product type	Examples	Key customer information
Liquid milk	Pasteurised, homogenised, toned, full-cream, skimmed, UHT	Fat category, pack volume, processing type, storage and use-by/best-before date as labelled
Cultured products	Curd/yogurt, buttermilk, lassi	Ingredients, culture/processing information where relevant, allergens, refrigeration and date marking
Cream & butter	Cream, butter, ghee	Milk allergen, ingredients, pack size, storage and handling instructions
Cheese & paneer	Paneer, cheese, cheese spreads	Ingredients, milk source where stated, allergen declaration, refrigeration and date marking
Frozen/dessert products	Ice cream, kulfi, dairy desserts	Allergens, frozen storage, thawing instructions and no-refreeze guidance if on label

3. Procurement & Supplier Approval Policy

• Purchase products only from approved, identifiable suppliers who can provide invoices and required product/food-business documentation.

• Before approval, assess supplier reliability, transport conditions, packaging integrity, product specifications, traceability and complaint/recall responsiveness.

• Check deliveries on arrival: supplier, product name, quantity, batch/lot code, date marking, seal/pack condition, visible contamination, leakage, odour where appropriate, and temperature where required.

• Reject or isolate products with broken seals, damaged packs, missing/illegible labels, evidence of thawing where frozen, abnormal appearance, expired dates, or temperatures outside the applicable specification.

• Record delivery date/time, supplier, lot/batch, quantity, checks performed, rejected quantity and corrective action.

• Do not mix unidentified stock with saleable stock. Keep suspect goods clearly marked and physically separated pending a decision.

4. Receiving, Storage & Cold-Chain Policy

• Follow the product label, supplier specification and local food-safety requirements for storage temperature and shelf life. Do not assume every dairy product has the same temperature limit.

• Keep chilled products in a monitored refrigerator/cold room; keep frozen products frozen as instructed. Use a suitable thermometer and record temperatures at a defined frequency.

• Maintain a temperature log with date/time, reading, staff initials and action taken if out of range. Verify thermometer accuracy according to the business procedure.

• Use FEFO (First Expiry, First Out): place products with the earliest valid date at the front, without hiding labels or dates.

• Store dairy products covered and away from raw meat, chemicals, cleaning products, waste, pests and other contamination sources. Separate allergens and prevent cross-contact where applicable.

• Avoid leaving chilled goods at room temperature during receiving, stocking, packing or delivery. Minimise door-open time and avoid overloading refrigerators.

• If a temperature excursion occurs, identify affected lots, isolate them, document the duration and readings, and seek a qualified food-safety decision. Do not sell product merely because it looks or smells normal.

• Clean and maintain storage equipment. Keep shelves, seals, drains and contact surfaces clean; record cleaning and maintenance.

5. Hygiene & Handling Policy

• Staff must wash hands before handling unpackaged products, after using the toilet, handling waste, touching phones, coughing/sneezing, or doing any task that may contaminate food.

• Wear clean work clothing and suitable hair restraints. Cover cuts with appropriate waterproof dressings; report illness that may create a food-safety risk and follow the business illness policy.

• Do not handle exposed products when unwell with symptoms that could contaminate food. The manager should apply local requirements and arrange safe reassignment where appropriate.

• Use clean, food-grade utensils and containers. Never reuse single-use packaging or place a clean utensil on an unclean surface.

• Use potable water for cleaning and food-contact purposes. Follow chemical dilution/contact-time instructions and keep chemicals away from food.

• Control pests, waste, condensation and standing water. Report damaged equipment, leaks, pests or sewage issues immediately.

• Train staff on hygiene, allergen awareness, temperature control, complaint escalation and product recall steps; maintain training records.

6. Packaging, Labelling & Product Integrity Policy

• Sell only packs with required and legible information. Depending on product and jurisdiction, this may include product name, ingredient list, allergen declaration, net quantity, date marking, storage instructions, batch/lot code, manufacturer/packer details, customer-care details, licence/registration details and nutrition information.

• Never alter, cover, extend or replace a date mark, batch code, ingredient list or required warning without lawful authorisation.

• Do not refill branded containers or transfer products into unlabelled containers unless the process is lawful, safe and correctly documented.

• Do not make unverified claims such as 'organic', 'A2', 'preservative-free', 'pure', 'medicinal', 'lactose-free' or 'suitable for everyone'. Claims must be accurate, substantiated and legally permitted.

• For loose products, display accurate product identity, price/unit, quantity basis and required consumer information. Use clean, food-grade dispensing equipment and protect the product from contamination.

• Keep packaging and labels for retained samples or investigations only where the business's documented plan requires it.

7. Pricing, Orders, Payment & Subscription Policy

• Display current prices clearly, including unit or pack size and any delivery fee, deposit, subscription charge or other mandatory charge before the customer confirms the order.

• Confirm the product, quantity, delivery/pick-up date, delivery window, address, contact method, total price and payment status in the order record.

• For recurring milk delivery, explain frequency, cut-off time for changes, holiday pauses, skipped deliveries, billing cycle, cancellation method and any refundable-container deposit.

• Do not substitute a product, size, brand or fat category without customer approval. If an item is unavailable, offer a refund or an agreed alternative.

• Issue a receipt or order confirmation. Keep payment records secure and do not request or store unnecessary payment-card credentials.

• If a price or order-entry error is identified, contact the customer promptly and resolve it fairly before dispatch where possible.

8. Delivery & Handover Policy

• Pack products to maintain the storage conditions required by their labels and prevent leaks, crushing, tampering and cross-contamination.

• Use clean delivery containers and suitable insulated/cold-chain equipment when required. Monitor delivery conditions according to the risk and product specification.

• Deliver to the confirmed address and agreed window where reasonably possible. Record delivery completion and any failed delivery attempt.

• At handover, advise the customer to refrigerate or freeze the product promptly according to its label. Do not leave temperature-sensitive products unattended unless the customer has explicitly agreed to a safe arrangement.

• If delivery is delayed or the cold chain may have failed, isolate the affected goods and notify the responsible manager. Do not deliver questionable stock.

• For failed delivery, wrong address or customer unavailability, follow the disclosed redelivery, return or refund procedure. Never return temperature-abused product to saleable stock.

9. Returns, Refunds, Replacements & Complaints

• Ask for the order number/receipt, product name, pack size, batch/lot code, date mark, purchase/delivery time, description of the issue and photos if the customer is comfortable providing them.

• Potential safety complaints (foreign object, suspected spoilage, illness, damaged seal, contamination or temperature concern) must be escalated immediately to the designated manager.

• Do not ask a customer to taste or consume a suspect product to confirm a complaint. Advise them to stop using it and retain the packaging and remaining product safely if feasible.

• For wrong, missing, damaged or quality-affected items, offer a fair remedy consistent with applicable law and the published policy: replacement, refund, credit or another agreed resolution.

• Food safety and legal rights take priority over restrictive store rules. Do not automatically reject a valid safety complaint only because the pack is opened or the receipt is missing; assess evidence fairly.

• Record the complaint, lot/batch, suspected cause, decision, refund/replacement, corrective action and closure date. Look for recurring trends.

10. Food Safety Incident, Withdrawal & Recall Policy

• Stop sale and isolate any product suspected to be unsafe, mislabelled, contaminated, temperature-abused or subject to a supplier/regulator recall.

• Mark isolated stock 'HOLD — DO NOT SELL' and record product, lot/batch, quantity, location, reason, date/time and person responsible.

• Notify the business owner/food-safety lead and contact the supplier and competent authority where required. Follow the legally required reporting and recall process for the location.

• Use traceability records to identify affected stock received, stock on hand, stock dispatched and customers who can be contacted lawfully.

• Communicate clearly with affected customers: identify the product and batch, explain the concern without speculation, state what they should do, and provide a contact route for refund or further instructions.

• Do not destroy records or quietly return suspect stock to sale. Document decisions, quantities recovered, customer contacts and final disposition.

• After closure, investigate root cause and introduce corrective action such as supplier review, equipment repair, staff retraining or revised checks.

11. Allergens, Nutrition & Special Dietary Questions

• Milk is a major food allergen. Many dairy products also contain other allergens depending on ingredients, such as nuts, soy, wheat/gluten or eggs. Check the actual label; do not guess.

• Prevent allergen cross-contact through suitable storage, cleaning, utensils and handling practices. Do not promise an allergen-free product unless the business can substantiate and control that claim.

• If a customer reports a milk allergy, clearly explain that milk and milk-derived products are not suitable unless a qualified healthcare professional has advised otherwise. Lactose-free dairy is still milk and is not the same as milk-allergen-free.

• Give factual information from the label or verified product specification. Do not provide medical advice or promise that a product will treat a health condition.

• Nutrition information, fat categories and ingredients vary by brand and formulation; refer to the package label or verified specification.

12. Customer Privacy & Records

• Collect only information needed to process orders, delivery, payment, customer support, safety alerts and legal obligations.

• Limit access to customer names, phone numbers, addresses, order history and complaint records to authorised staff.

• Do not share customer data with unrelated parties or use it for marketing without the required permission and legal basis.

• Keep records only for the period required by applicable law and the business retention schedule; protect paper and digital records from unauthorised access.

• Provide a clear contact route for privacy questions, corrections or complaints, subject to applicable law.

13. Staff Responsibilities & Daily Checklist

• **Opening:** check refrigeration/freezer readings; inspect cleanliness, pests, equipment and stock condition; review near-expiry and held stock.

• **Receiving:** verify supplier, packs, dates, batch codes, quantities and required temperatures; record and isolate nonconforming goods.

• **During operation:** wash hands, use clean tools, prevent cross-contamination, maintain cold chain, rotate FEFO stock and keep labels visible.

• **Closing:** secure products at required temperatures; clean equipment and work surfaces; dispose of waste; record temperatures, incidents and maintenance needs.

• **Manager:** review logs, investigate deviations, confirm staff training, approve supplier changes, manage complaints and lead recall decisions.

14. Suggested Record Templates

Record	Minimum fields to capture
Receiving log	Date/time; supplier; product; lot/batch; date mark; quantity; temperature if relevant; pack condition; accepted/rejected; initials
Temperature log	Date/time; equipment ID; reading; acceptable range from specification; corrective action; initials
Cleaning log	Area/equipment; task; chemical and dilution where applicable; completion time; staff initials; verification
Complaint log	Order; customer contact; product/lot; issue; purchase date; evidence; risk level; action; refund/replacement; closure
Recall/hold log	Product/lot; reason; quantity received/on hand/sold; hold location; contacts; authority/supplier notifications; final disposition
Training log	Staff name; topic; date; trainer; competency check; refresher due date

15. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

How should I store milk after buying it?

Follow the storage instruction printed on the pack. Refrigerate products labelled for refrigeration as soon as possible and keep them within the stated conditions. Do not rely on smell alone to judge safety.

How long will milk stay fresh after opening?

There is no single safe number for every product. Follow the pack's after-opening instructions and date marking, and keep it at the specified temperature. If the label is unclear, contact the manufacturer or seller for verified guidance.

Can I drink milk after the date printed on the pack?

Do not use a product beyond the date where the label or local rules say it must not be consumed. Date-marking terms have specific meanings that vary by jurisdiction and product. When in doubt, do not consume it; ask the seller or manufacturer.

Why does milk sometimes smell or taste different?

Differences may arise from product type, processing, feed, storage or normal product characteristics. A sour, rancid, unusual or otherwise suspicious change can also indicate a quality or safety problem. Do not taste a product to test whether it is safe; stop using it and report the issue.

What should I do if the pack is swollen, leaking or has a broken seal?

Do not consume it. Keep the package and date/batch details, separate it from other food and contact the seller with your order or purchase details.

What if the delivered item is wrong or missing?

Contact customer support as soon as possible with the order number, item and delivery details. The business should check the dispatch record and arrange an appropriate correction, replacement, credit or refund under its policy and applicable law.

Can I return an opened dairy product?

Return and refund options depend on the reason and applicable consumer law. For suspected spoilage, contamination, wrong product or another safety concern, report it even if opened; do not consume the remainder. Keep the pack and batch details if feasible.

Is lactose-free milk safe for someone with a milk allergy?

No assumption should be made. Lactose-free dairy generally still contains milk proteins and is not the same as milk-allergen-free. A person with a milk allergy should follow their healthcare professional's advice and the product's allergen label.

Are curd, paneer, butter, ghee and cheese suitable for everyone?

No. These products differ in ingredients, processing and nutritional composition, and many contain milk allergen. Check the ingredient and allergen labels and seek qualified dietary advice for medical concerns.

Can I freeze milk?

Only freeze a product if its packaging or manufacturer guidance permits it. Freezing may affect texture or separation, and it does not correct unsafe handling. Use suitable food-grade packaging and follow the manufacturer's thawing instructions.

Can thawed dairy products be refrozen?

Follow the specific label and manufacturer instructions. If a product has warmed beyond its permitted conditions or the cold chain is uncertain, do not refreeze or sell it; seek a food-safety decision.

Why does cream or milk separate?

Some separation can occur depending on product type and processing, but unusual separation, curdling, gas, swelling or off-odour may indicate a problem. Follow the label and contact the seller if you are unsure; do not taste suspect products.

Does boiling make spoiled milk safe?

Do not rely on boiling to make spoiled or temperature-abused milk safe. If it appears suspect or has been stored incorrectly, discard it or follow official food-safety advice.

What does pasteurised mean?

Pasteurisation is a controlled heat treatment intended to reduce harmful microorganisms. It does not mean a product can be stored without following its label; refrigeration and handling instructions still matter.

What is UHT milk?

UHT means ultra-high-temperature processing, usually combined with aseptic packaging. Some unopened UHT products can be stored at room temperature as directed on the label, but after opening they generally require the stated refrigerated storage instructions.

How can I check the product's batch or lot number?

Look for a printed code on the pack, often near the date mark or seal. Keep this code when reporting a complaint because it helps the seller trace the production or supply batch.

Do dairy products contain preservatives?

Ingredients vary by product and brand. Check the ingredient list on the exact pack; do not assume all products have the same formulation.

Can you guarantee that a product is organic, A2 or additive-free?

Only if the exact product is appropriately certified or the claim is otherwise substantiated and legally permitted. Staff should refer to approved product information and must not make unsupported claims.

What payment methods are accepted?

Insert your actual options here: cash, UPI, card, bank transfer, wallet or other approved methods. Confirm the total price and any delivery or subscription fee before payment.

Can I pause or cancel a regular milk delivery?

Insert your service rules here: notice/cut-off time, how to pause or cancel, billing adjustments, holiday schedule and any container deposit/refund terms. Explain these conditions before a subscription begins.

What if my delivery is late?

Contact the service number listed on your order confirmation. Provide your order number and address area. The business should share an updated estimate and explain the available options if the delivery cannot be completed.

How do I report a suspected food-safety issue?

Stop consuming the product, keep the pack and batch/date information, and contact the seller immediately. If someone is seriously unwell, seek appropriate medical care. The seller should escalate the concern promptly and follow reporting duties.

Can staff tell me whether a product is suitable for a medical condition?

Staff can read verified ingredient and nutrition information but should not diagnose or prescribe. For allergies, intolerance, pregnancy, infant feeding or other medical concerns, consult a qualified healthcare professional.

How do you protect my contact and delivery details?

The business should use customer data only for legitimate order, delivery, support, safety and legal purposes, restrict access, and follow applicable privacy requirements. Add the business's actual privacy contact and retention policy here.

Who can I contact for a complaint?

Add your business's support phone, email, operating hours and escalation contact here. Include order number, product name, batch/lot code and a short description to help the team investigate.

16. Customisation Checklist Before Publishing

• Add business name, address, phone, email, support hours and complaint escalation contact.

• List the exact products and brands sold; attach verified specifications and allergen information.

• Insert approved storage limits and date-handling instructions from product labels/supplier specifications; do not invent shelf lives.

• Set delivery area, delivery windows, cut-off times, fees, failed-delivery rules and subscription pause/cancellation terms.

• Set the actual return/refund/replacement procedure and ensure it does not unlawfully restrict customer rights.

• Confirm applicable food-business licence/registration, labelling, packaging, tax, weights-and-measures, consumer and privacy obligations with the relevant authority or qualified adviser.

• Train all staff on the final version, maintain records and review after any incident, product change, supplier change or regulatory update.

17. Disclaimer & Approval

This template is educational and operational guidance. It does not certify that a business or product complies with every legal requirement. Requirements differ by jurisdiction, product category, sales channel and business size. Have the final document reviewed by the responsible food-safety professional or competent authority before relying on it as a formal policy.

Prepared by	_____	**Date**	_____
Reviewed by	_____	**Date**	_____
Approved by	_____	**Effective from**	_____